

Q40 | Correct option: 5 rings - five continents of the world united by the Olympic Movement

Source: International Olympic Committee Olympic Brand Centre, Olympic Symbol — PDF page 3 of the printed IOC Olympic Symbol webpage; quotation and creation-of-rings text

"These five rings represent the five parts of the world now won over to Olympism and ready to accept its fruitful rivalries. In addition, the six colours combined in this way represent the colours of every country without exception. [...] This, truly, is an international emblem."



Pierre de Coubertin

"L'emblème et le drapeau de 1914" in "Revue Olympique", No. 92, August 1913.

The Olympic rings are the visual representation of Olympism and the symbol of the Olympic Movement.

Some of the Olympic Movement stakeholders are able to use the Olympic rings as part of their emblems, to demonstrate their commitment to Olympism and the Olympic values. By using the Olympic rings, these organisations join their own identities and attributes with those of the Olympic brand. In parallel, by joining the values of these organisations, the Olympic brand becomes a truly global symbol that is representative of the entire Olympic Movement.

To protect this asset, the IOC benefits from an exceptional international legal instrument. Adopted in 1981 and administered by the World Intellectual Property Organization (WIPO), the Nairobi Treaty on the Protection of the Olympic Symbol obliges each state that has ratified it to refuse or invalidate the registration as a mark and to prohibit the use for commercial purposes of any sign consisting of or containing the Olympic symbol, except with the IOC's authorisation.

The Olympic rings over time

Creation of the Olympic rings

The Olympic rings first appeared at the top of a letter written by Baron Pierre de Coubertin in 1913. Drawn and coloured by hand, the rings were conceived as an “international emblem” to reflect the global reach of the Olympic Movement following the Olympic Games Stockholm 1912, which was the first time that athletes had come from all five continents to compete.